

Common yanyu (proverbs) you'll hear in Mandarin Chinese

Yanyu are the proverbs your Chinese friend's grandmother would quote during family dinners. They're longer than chengyu, usually a full sentence, and focus on practical wisdom rather than literary references.

熟能生巧 (shú néng shēng qiǎo)

This is the Chinese version of "practice makes perfect." The meaning is identical to the English version. You'll hear this whenever someone's learning a new skill, whether that's cooking, playing an instrument, or yeah, learning Chinese.

一分耕耘，一分收获 (yī fēn gēng yún, yī fēn shōu huò)

Literal translation: "one part plowing, one part harvest." It means you get out what you put in. Parents love using this phrase to motivate kids studying for exams. The agricultural metaphor runs deep in Chinese culture since farming shaped society for thousands of years.

三个臭皮匠，顶个诸葛亮 (sān gè chòu pí jiàng, dǐng gè Zhū gě Liàng)

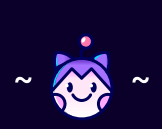
This saying translates to "three cobblers equal one Zhuge Liang." Zhuge Liang was a legendary strategist from the Three Kingdoms period, basically the smartest guy in ancient China. The proverb means that collective wisdom from ordinary people can match a genius working alone. Pretty similar to "two heads are better than one" in the English idiom.

师傅领进门，修行在个人 (shī fu lǐng jìn mén, xiū xíng zài gè rén)

Meaning: "the master leads you to the door, but cultivation depends on the individual." Teachers can only do so much. The real learning happens through your own effort. This one gets quoted constantly in martial arts movies and language learning forums.

路遥知马力，日久见人心 (lù yáo zhī mǎ lì, rì jiǔ jiàn rén xīn)

Literal meaning: "a long road tests a horse's strength, time reveals a person's heart." Basically, you only truly know someone's character after spending significant time with them. The phrase emphasizes that first impressions can deceive.



Everyday suyu (common sayings) for casual conversation

Suyu are the expressions that make your Mandarin sound natural rather than textbook-formal. These are the phrases native speakers drop into everyday conversation without thinking twice.

马马虎虎 (mǎ ma hū hu)

This idiom literally means "horse horse tiger tiger," which sounds completely random. The actual meaning is "so-so" or "just okay." When someone asks how your day went and you say 马马虎虎, you're saying it was mediocre, nothing special. You'll hear this response constantly in casual small talk.

拍马屁 (pāi mǎ pì)

Literal translation: "to pat a horse's butt." The real meaning? Kissing up to someone, flattering them excessively. If your coworker constantly compliments the boss for obviously selfish reasons, what they're doing is 拍马屁. The expression comes from Mongol culture where patting a warrior's horse was considered flattery.

走马观花 (zǒu mǎ guān huā)

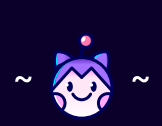
This phrase means "looking at flowers while riding a horse," used to describe a superficial or rushed observation of something. Like when tourists speed through a museum taking selfies without actually appreciating the art. The idiom suggests you're moving too fast to gain real understanding.

临时抱佛脚 (lín shí bào fó jiǎo)

Literally "hugging Buddha's feet at the last minute." This describes cramming before an exam or seeking help only when disaster strikes. Students use this all the time to describe their terrible study habits. The imagery comes from people who ignore religion their whole lives but suddenly pray desperately when facing a crisis.

吃醋 (chī cù)

This simple two-character expression literally means "eat vinegar" but actually means to be jealous, especially in romantic situations. If your girlfriend gets mad because you talked to another woman, that's 吃醋. The phrase has roots in a Tang Dynasty story about a jealous wife who drank vinegar rather than accept her husband taking a concubine.



Xiehouyu: Two-part allegorical sayings in Mandarin

Xiehouyu are probably the most entertaining type of Chinese idiom. They work like inside jokes, where you say the first part and everyone understands the implied second half. These expressions showcase Chinese wordplay and humor.

八仙过海 (bā xiān guò hǎi)

The full saying is ^{bāxiānguòhǎi}八仙过海, ^{gèxiānshéntōng}各显神通, which means "the Eight Immortals cross the sea, each displaying their special powers." In practice, people usually just say the first part. It's used to describe situations where everyone tackles a problem using their unique skills or methods. The reference comes from a famous Chinese legend where eight immortal beings each used different magical abilities to cross the ocean.

肉包子打狗 (ròu bāo zi dǎ gǒu)

Full version: ^{ròubāozidǎgǒu}肉包子打狗, ^{yǒuqùwúhuí}有去无回. Literal meaning: "throwing a meat bun at a dog, it goes but never returns." This idiom is used to describe wasted effort or resources you'll never get back. If you lend money to that one friend who never pays anyone back, you're throwing meat buns at dogs.

泥菩萨过江 (ní pú sà guò jiāng)

Complete saying: ^{nípúsàguòjiāng}泥菩萨过江, ^{zìshēnnánbǎo}自身难保, meaning "a clay Buddha crossing the river can barely save itself." It's used when someone's in such bad shape they can't possibly help others in Chinese language and culture. Like when your broke friend asks to borrow money from you when you're also broke.

外甥打灯笼 (wài shēng dǎ dēng lóng)

Full version: ^{wàishēngdǎdēnglóng}外甥打灯笼, ^{zhàojiù}照旧 (舅). This is a pure pun. ^{zhàojiù}照旧 means "as usual" but ^{zhào niú}照舅 would mean "illuminating uncle." Since 外甥 means nephew and holding a lantern illuminates